The Father

By Sharon Olds

His Stillness

The doctor said to my father, "You asked me
to tell you when nothing more could be done.
That's what I'm telling you now." My father
sat quite still, as he always did,
especially not moving his eyes. I had thought
he would rave if he understood he would die,
wave his arms and cry out. He sat up,
thin, and clean, in his clean gown,
like a holy man. The doctor said,
"There are things we can do which might give you time,
but we cannot cure you." My father said,
"Thank you." And he sat, motionless, alone,
with the dignity of a foreign leader.
I sat beside him. This was my father.
He had known he was mortal. I had feared they would
have to
tie him down. I had not remembered

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he had always held still and kept quiet to bear things,
the liquor a way to keep still. I had not
known him. My father had dignity. At the
end of his life, his life began
to wake in me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sharon Olds
Book: The Father
ISBN: 978-0679740025
Publisher: Knopf
Date (Month/Year): April 1992

INTRODUCTION

Sharon Olds grew up in San Francisco, the daughter of an abusive, alcoholic father. But when her father is diagnosed with uncurable throat cancer, she begins to examine not only his rapid decline, but their relationship. This collection highlights the complicated and difficult relationship we often have with parents, death and illness and is an unbelievably powerful journey of love and hate. The Father by Sharon Olds

NATIONAL USE

Late Poem to My Father

Suddenly I thought of you
as a child in [your father's] house, the unlit rooms
and the hot fireplace with the man in front of it,
silent. You moved through the heavy air
in your physical beauty, a boy of seven,
helpless, smart, there were things the man
did near you, and he was your father,
the mold by which you were made. Down in the
cellar, the barrels of sweet apples,
picked at their peak from the tree, rotted and
rotted, and past the cellar door
the creek ran and ran, and something was
not given to you, or something was
taken from you that you were born with,
so that even at 30 and 40 you set the
oily medicine to your lips
every night, the poison to help you
drop down unconscious. I always though the
point was what you did to us

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as a grown man, but then I remembered
that child being formed in front of the fire, the
tiny bones inside his soul
twisted in greenstick fractures, the small
tendons that hold the heart in place
snapped. And what they did to you
you did not do to me. When I love you now,
I like to think that I am giving my love
directly to that boy in the fiery room,

As if it could reach him in time.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sharon Olds
Book: The Gold Cell
ISBN: 978-0394747705
Publisher: Knopf
Date (Month/Year): February 1987

TRANSITION

Children are incredibly susceptible to parental influence and neglect. As a result, growing up with an alcoholic parent can have serious consequences in both the short-term and the long-term. In Saturn, Olds recalls an image of her father lying on a couch, consuming his child (like the Olympian god) by indifference.

Saturn

He lay on the couch night after night,
mouth open, the darkness of the room
filling his mouth, and no one knew
my father was eating his children. He seemed to
rest so quietly, vast body
inert on the sofa, big hand
fallen away from the glass.
What could be more passive than a man
passed out every night--and yet as he lay
on his back, snoring, our lives slowly
disappeared down the hole of his life.
My brother's arm went in up to the shoulder
and he bit it off, and sucked at the wound

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as one sucks at the sockets of lobster. He took
my brother's head between his lips
and snapped it like a cherry off the stem. You would
have
seen
only a large, handsome man
heavily asleep, unconscious. And yet
somewhere in his head his soil-colored eyes
were open, the circles of the whites glittering
as he crunched the torso of his child between his jaws,
crushed the bones like the soft shells of crabs
and the delicacies of the genitals
rolled back along his tongue. In the nerves of his gums
and
bowels he knew what he was doing and he could not
stop himself, like orgasm, his
boy's feet crackling like two raw fish
between his teeth. This is what he wanted,
to take that life into his mouth
and show what a man could do--show his son
what a man's life was.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sharon Olds
Book: The Sign of Saturn
ISBN: 978-0436200298
Publisher: Secker and Warburg
Date (Month/Year): March 1991

TRANSITION

Faced with her father's eminent death, Olds struggles with feelings of both love and hate, brokenness and forgiveness.

The Struggle

When the minister would come into the hospital room
my father would try to sit up, he would cry out
Up! Up! For us to raise his bed-head, then
silently he would wrestle himself
up, sweating, he would end up
leaning n the pillows, panting, a man, erect.
The minister would kiss him, they would pray, then chat,
he would hold his eyes open unblinking,
rigid adherent to the protocol of the living,
he would sit for the whole visit, and then,

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the minute the man was out the door, cry
out Down! Down! And we would lower him
down, and he would pass out.
Later the doctor would pay a call and as
soon as my father saw that white coat
he would start to labor up, desperate
to honor the coat, at a glimpse of it he would
start to stir like a dog who could not
not obey. He would lurch, pause,
then thrust up slowly and unevenly, like a
camel, a half-born animal – the way,
they say, his soul will pull itself up
out of his dead body and wobbingly
walk. And then, one day, he tried,
his brain ordered his body to heave up,
the sweat rose in his pores but he was not
moving, he cast up his eyes as the minister
leaned to kis him, he lay and stared, it was
nothing like the night he had lain on the couch passed
out, nothing. [For] Now he was alive . . .

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Author: Sharon Olds
Book: The Sign of Saturn
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Beyond Harm

A week after my father died
suddenly I understood
his fondness for me was safe – nothing
could touch it. In that last year,
his face would sometimes brighten when I would
enter the room, and his wife said
that once, when he was half asleep,
he smiled when she said my name. He respected
my spunk – when they tied me to the chair, that time
they were tying up someone he respected, and when
he did not speak, for weeks, I was one of the
beings to whom he was not speaking,
someone with a place in his life. The last
week he even said it, once,

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by mistake. I walked into his room
'How are you' and he said 'I love you
too.' From then on, I had
that word to lose. Right up to the last
moment, I could make some mistake, offend him,
and with one of his old mouths of disgust he could
re-skew my life. I did not think of it much,
I was helping to take care of him,
wiping his face and watching him.
But then, a while after he died,
I suddenly thought, with amazement, he will always
love me now, and I laughed – he was dead, dead!

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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier